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Anamorphism and Repetition in Fez's Reorientation

In 2012, Polytron released the experimental and independent 2D puzzle-platformer *Fez*. Fez's story begins with its player character, Gomez, encountering an extradimensional being known as the Hexahedron, which reveals to Gomez that he truly lives in a three-dimensional world; the Hexahedron then blesses Gomez with the titular fez. This allows him to perceive the world in three dimensions, but only by fragmenting his world into four 2-D faces. However, this exchange between realities also leads to the fragmenting of the Hexahedron, thrusting Gomez and the player into a quest that will rely on their ability to utilize the power of the fez to explore the game's world and attempt to stabilize reality. This power, which takes the form of the game's primary mechanic, *reorientation*, allows Gomez to rotate his two-dimensional vision along a three-dimensional axis; the world becomes a cube that he can navigate by rotating between its four faces. These different perspectives quite literally change the positions of objects in Gomez's reality, allowing for the player and Gomez to navigate between sets of possible actions when they seemingly lack a way forward or a clear goal. However, with the expansion and opening up of new possibility spaces, certain aspects of the previous one are lost to the background. Thus, as Gomez and the player navigate this fragmentary and non-linear world, divided up in four perspectives, they must repeatedly traverse the same environments over and over again to attempt to exhaust their possibilities. This necessity of repetition, reliant on a shifting perspective, is further extended by the game's hidden language and unsolvable puzzles, pointing towards a potential inexhaustibility of action that's directly mediated by what one is capable of perceiving as possible.

The story of Fez starts in Gomez's homeworld, Villageville. When the player opens up the game, Gomez arises from sleep, exits his home, and receives a letter from the top of the village from the old man, Geezer. Geezer's letter informs Gomez that he has something important to tell him and that he needs to meet him above the village, because "Today is special day," (Polytron). This section, wherein the player must control Gomez to reach the top of Villageville, operates as a standard sort of tutorial for the game's core platforming mechanics; a simple goal is established: reach the top of the village by growing accustomed to moving, jumping, and grabbing onto ledges. As most video games go, an introductory tutorial allows the player to get used to their primary means for exploring and navigating the goal structures of the world. This kind of learning, adjusting to a new system, or *mechanical set*, for the selection of correct inputs in response to an environment, falls neatly within Gregory Bateson's category of Learning II, wherein a player makes "a corrective change in the set of alternatives from which choice is made," (310). To take up playing a video game, the player must first learn the set of options from which their choices are made, learning to solve the kind of obstacles and goals presented by the game system by learning to utilize the tools provided for them in the form of mechanics. Learning I in this case, as a "*change in specificity of response* by correction of errors of choice within a set of alternatives" could simply be the player's ability to properly navigate the environment using their provided mechanical set, moving and jumping at the right time to reach their desired positions (310).

The mechanical set encountered in FEZ's tutorial doesn't necessarily operate in any especially different way from the standards of the 2-D platforming genre. The options of moving and jumping to reach a given platform have been comfortable staples of the genre since its conception. For the initiated 2-D platformer player, these familiar conventions operate in-line

with Bateson's own understanding of "set learning" in Learning II, where, for a player who encounters new types of problems that utilize a previously learned mechanical set, "there [is] a carry-over of learning from one problem to the next," (312). These conventions then permit a player of FEZ who has previously learned-to-learn how to play a 2-D platformer a certain kind of comfortability within the context of this tutorial. While the player will likely still encounter some difficulty on the part of Learning I as they adjust to the specific game-feel and speed of Gomez's own jump, the overall context of the game's mechanics may feel like home.

This comfortability of the player is in fact reflected by the overall tone and atmosphere established by the characters found in Villageville. As Gomez, and the player controlling him, make their way to meet Geezer, they have a chance to interact with these villagers. Here, the player gets to learn a little about the state of this world while familiarizing themselves with the core mechanics. One of the first villagers the player can talk to states that his favorite shape "is square! Not cube, that's for sure! Because there is no such thing," (Polytron). The next tells Gomez and the player that she "loves village" and that she's lived here her whole life, (Polytron). The importance of these two short snippets of dialogue, beyond their general charm and ability to set the humorous tone of the game's world, is the way in which both of their perceptions are in some ways confined to familiarity. The comfortability of the village and the familiarity with the two-dimensional world reflects the initiated player's own familiarity with the mechanical set of 2D platforming. However, an old man just below the schoolhouse tells Gomez, and the player, that "Reality is perception. Perception is subjective," pointing towards the fact that there may be other ways of seeing, and being in, the world than what is taken as a given in the familiar Villageville (Polytron).

This claim of a subjective structuring of reality, as well as the limits of perception established in Villageville by a comfortability of perspective neatly align with Abraham Moles's studies on the *apperceptual limit* of humans as receptors of information. In the case of Villageville's inability to see outside their familiar two-dimensional perspective, Abraham Moles's understanding of how perception is constituted by a subject's *a priori knowledge* is a helpful place to start. According to Moles:

We were content to indicate at various points that the psychological structure of the information receptor was connected with his present situation and his sociocultural past. For example, we observed that the "apperceptual limit" is a function of the subject's education, for example, in music. (93).

Here, the ability for any given individual to make sense of incoming information, as a receptor of said information, is a function directly tied to a combination of previous learning, as well as the given context of the present. The citizens of Villageville can then be understood as being unable to conceive of incoming signals or stimuli that exist outside of the context of their *a priori* perception. The most important aspect of reality that exists outside their capacity for perception is namely the existence of a third-dimension, of cubes, that they simply lack the ability to parse as information. This inability to perceive outside the second-dimension operates as a kind of comfort that shields them from the potential uncertainty of the limits of their perception, allowing them to sit comfortably within their familiar mechanical sets, much like the player accustomed to platforming mechanics.

Their familiarity and comfortability with their environment, playing a core role in their present situations, afford them the ability to consider their frames of reference as "good-enough" to navigate their day-to-day lives within the village. They simply lack any exigence to reach

beyond this apperceptual limit and to learn new ways of seeing. In her essay, *The Modal Structure of Narrative Universes*, Marie-Laurie Ryan describes a concept helpful to explicate the comfortability of the perspective of Villageville, that she names productive conflict, which is essential to the exigence of narrative action. This essay, in general, argues for a conception of narrative that moves beyond a strictly linear chart or sequence of events in time; rather, this view of narrative could be seen more closely akin to a sequence of moves in a game. In order for an actant or player to feel motivated to make a move within a narrative, there must be some sort of driving force, a separation between what is desired by or expected of a character and the real world they occupy. Ryan conceptualizes this essential dissonance through the relative frames of model-worlds which form subjunctive models, ideas of what the world could or should be. Ryan describes the generation of productive conflict as:

Whenever some of the propositions of a private world (K-world or model-world) become unsatisfied in the actual world, the narrative universe falls into a state of conflict. This event can be visualized as a satellite of the actual world leaving its orbit. (733).

In the beginning of Fez, there lacks both a significant-enough distance between model-worlds of the villagers, including Gomez, and reality to necessitate narrative action or shifts in perspective. The alignment between the village's perception of reality and their actual world is functional enough that the gap of the third-dimension bears no relevancy to the desires or lives of its citizens. No productive conflict exists that necessitates any sort of narrative movement or purposeful shifts in perspective for how moves are made within their lives. The subjective reality of Villageville exists in a state of equilibrium. However, today is a special day and Gomez's knowledge of reality will soon be expanded, fragmenting reality itself and thrusting his

model-worlds out of orbit, into disequilibrium, necessitating the use of this new knowledge in order to put the world back together.

As the player completes the platforming tutorial and Gomez reaches the highest point in Villageville to meet Geezer, Geezer proclaims, “Adventure is ready! It’s Gomez time!” (Polytron). After a couple seconds of waiting around for Gomez time, the shape of a hexagon begins to form in the sky above Gomez, until the outline of its shape is filled with a bright, white light. The now-filled-in hexagon begins to rotate, extending beyond the two-dimensional perspective it was viewed from previously, breaking the a priori conceptions of 2D space held by the player and citizens of Villageville. After radiating an even brighter light that engulfs the entire screen, Gomez is teleported to a new environment, and the shape, properly known as the Hexahedron, takes on its actual form, with gold tetris-like patterns lining its exterior. The Hexahedron begins to speak to Gomez in an unknown language, presented in written form as sequences of patterned squares and in verbal form as seemingly indecipherable noise. It then casts a ray of light down onto Gomez, bringing him up into the sky underneath it, while this new language begins to fall down from the Hexahedron’s light onto him as well. When this language is cast onto Gomez, he begins to rotate along with the Hexahedron this time, instead of it merely rotating on its own. The truth of the three-dimensional world comes into view for Gomez and the player both; Gomez’s knowledge of reality has been thrust beyond the previous limitations of his perception.

To contextualize this scene within the idea of an apperceptual limit, it might be useful to first start with Moles’s conception of the difference between noise and signal: this distinction is central to the way receptors filter information from their environment. To Moles, the human receptor is capable of extracting a signal, and thus information, from its environment only

through the psychological Gestalt of figure/ground, wherein a form is discerned in contrast to an uninterested background. From the mixture of sensory information that comprises this background, “the meaningful signal must emerge, much as theatrical action stands out against a backdrop characterized by its lack of interest,” (77). Noise however, operates as some kind of interference in the receptor’s capability to discern the intent of the message: a noise “*is a signal that the sender does not want to transmit*,” (79). This helps to contextualize the nature of the Hexahedron’s language; while this language can later be deciphered, the meaning of this language is lost to the uninformed player, skewing the Hexahedron’s intent and arriving as only the signal of a signal. By signalling a lack of a priori knowledge, this noisy language, when cast down onto Gomez, brings about a change in his perspective, dragging the camera around in repetitive circles, revealing the amount of information previously dissimulated by the perceptual limits of two-dimensions. The majority of the three-dimensional world, which previously operated as a mere background-noise, is transformed from noise through a sort of injection of a noisy signal. The message that rains down onto Gomez simply reads, “You dummy, the world is three dimensions!” (Polytron). Despite the inability for the player or Gomez to currently decipher these signals, which the Hexahedron even points out, the introduction of a signal outside the bounds of perception operates as a sort of catalyst, expanding the limits of Gomez’s knowledge by showing him how much information from the three-dimensional world has been lost to the background of a two-dimensional system of perception.

To continue the application of Bateson’s theory of learning, beyond learning-to-learn, or Learning II, there exists a third form of learning that completely reorganizes how a player might choose between different mechanical sets, or choices of action. Bateson defines Learning III as “a corrective change in the system of *sets* of alternatives from which choice is made,” wherein an

organism's habitual understanding of reality, and thus their ability to discern between different contexts in the modality of Learning II, becomes modified (310). He notes that despite the rarity of this sort of learning, as well as the difficulty of conceptualizing it, it does occur occasionally "in psychotherapy, religious conversion, and in other sequences in which there is profound reorganization of character," (317). This encounter with the Hexahedron, a notably sublime sequence that leads to a profound reorganization of Gomez's perception of reality, and thus of his own place in the world, seems to be a moment likely to generate this kind of learning. The apperceptual limit of two-dimensions, which establishes the context for the game's mechanical action set, is revealed by the Hexahedron to itself be a system by which the context of action is discerned. To see beyond two-dimensions is not simply the ability to adapt to a new context, or to learn a new mechanic, but rather, it is a kind of learning and knowledge that will allow Gomez and the player to filter through the information that determines the context of their available actions, turning their entire perceptual system into a manually operated figure/ground distinction.

After the truth of reality is revealed and the Hexahedron's spinning winds down to a halt, it briefly disappears and another ray of light is cast down onto Gomez. The titular fez falls down within the light, rotating along the three-dimensional axis, until it lands squarely atop Gomez's head. Gomez does a little joyful hop, the Hexahedron reappears, and the player is prompted to use either of the triggers on a controller, or the A and D keys on the keyboard to "change [their] perspective," (Polytron). Here the player acquires the game's most central mechanic and the literalization of Learning III, *reorientation*; with reorientation, the player can shift the two-dimensional view of the world provided by the game's feedback, to the neighboring left or right faces of the three-dimensional plane, manually altering the context of their action. However, as the player follows the game's instructions and tests out this new mechanic, shifting

their perspective of the world relative to Gomez's position, the Hexahedron begins to rotate at an increasingly rapid speed until fracturing into numerous cubes. The camera's perspective continues to rotate without the player's input as various forms of static and ASCII symbols begin to overtake the screen, until the game finally freezes and restarts bringing the player back to the title screen. However, the title screen is different this time; the word FEZ begins to glitch and fragment into three different angles, individually colored red, green and blue, the colors of the human eye's photoreceptors, gesturing towards the fragmentation of the player's, as well as Gomez's, entire visual apparatus.

The attainment of Learning III, as well as its effects on the organism that experiences it, is notably very different from the other two forms of learning which don't necessarily challenge the fundamental structure of how context and choices are determined. To Bateson, this kind of learning holds the potential to quite literally destroy the organism's conception of selfhood:

To the degree that a man achieves Learning III, and learns to perceive and act in terms of the contexts of contexts, his "self" will take on a sort of irrelevance. The conception of "self" will no longer function as a nodal argument in the punctuation of experience. (320).

This literal loss of self occurs as a result of the organism's realization of a new system for informing contexts for action, given that the idea of a "self" could be considered as an aggregate of (consciously or unconsciously) learned contexts for interaction. To acquire the ability to perceive the *context of contexts* necessarily leads to a realization of the self as just that, a condensed aggregate of fragmentary contexts. Bateson further notes that even "the attempt at level III can be dangerous" as some who approach it may induce a sort of psychosis, wherein they become unable to even use the first-person pronoun, (321). This fragmentation that occurs

as a result of Gomez's enlightenment then, seems only natural, as his conception of previously established contexts for mechanical action are expanded to the third-dimension, the context of contexts, revealing the fragmentary nature of his own two-dimension perception.

When the player opens up the game again, Gomez wakes up in his room in the exact same way as when the game first started; the only difference this time is that he now wears the fez, and holds the power to reorient the context for action at will. When Gomez leaves his room he's greeted by a small extradimensional entity, Dot, who informs Gomez that something went wrong during his encounter with the Hexahedron. Dot tells Gomez that the fragmented pieces of the Hexahedron must be put back together in order to prevent the universe from collapsing, and that he'll be joining Gomez and the player on this journey. The Hexahedron has broken apart into 32 total cubes: 17 cubes and 120 cube-bits, which form a cube when 8 are gathered; this task of collection forms the game's primary, and ultimate goal. This ultimate goal could be thought of as a subjunctive model-world that generates productive conflict within Ryan's conception of narrative. Due to the fracturing of reality as a result of Gomez's encounter with the Hexahedron, Gomez is now tasked with putting the world back together, thrusting him outside of the confines of the previously familiar Villageville as a result of him being thrust outside of the confines of his previous a priori perception. The ability to achieve this goal, and to put the world back into equilibrium will require the player to utilize their now fractured image of reality and 2D platformer conventions, i.e. the mechanic of reorientation, to maneuver through a world now composed of four different perspectives.

Reorientation, as a mechanic, is notably different from the other core mechanics of the game; instead of simply operating within the world of the game, a press of the triggers or mapped buttons literally changes the reality and possibility space of the game world. To unpack

the complexity of this mechanic, it requires a foundation in the fundamental structure of *feedback*, the “multi-modal stimuli intended to convey perceptual information about the game’s structural elements: its underlying ends (goals) and the available means to achieve them (mechanics)” (Cardona et al., 4). Feedback, according to Cardona et al.’s model, is how the player gains information about the world of the game, as well as their mechanical set within that world; reorientation, as a mechanic that changes the player’s 2D perspective of FEZ’s 3D map, operates then as a literal manipulation of feedback. This filtration of information, since facing one side of the game’s world requires a transformation of previously available information into background noise, falls neatly in line with Moles’s conception of the role of the human receptor’s intention in parsing signal from noise: “in the case of messages from the environment to the individual, the transmitter as an individual does not exist; only the receptor remains. We generalize our definition: *A noise is a sound we do not want to hear*,” (79). Reorientation operates as a means by which the player can shift their given context for action by manually altering the feedback of the world provided to them by the game system.

To further elaborate the functionality of this mechanic, and the way in which this manipulation of feedback reconstructs the possibility space of action, and thus operates as a manipulation of context i.e. Bateson, is Ryan’s conception of the difference between state and event propositions. Ryan defines a state proposition as the list of truth values about the state of things in the storyworld, such as the location of an object (718). Contrasting to state propositions, event propositions are processes that affect changes in the truth values held by state propositions, such as mechanics in game systems. Reorientation, using this model, could be thought of as an event proposition that, by manipulating feedback, deliberately changes the truth values

(locations) of the environment, which permit different kinds of event propositions, or mechanical sets, to occur within the game's immediate narrative.

The first platforming puzzle that the player and Gomez must face after leaving Villageville functions as a straightforward tutorial for how this feedback driven, context manipulation operates. The player enters an environment consisting of a single tower, with climbable vines snaking their way up it. From the initial perspective, only a small portion of these vines are visible, which requires the player to shift their perspective to the right one time to see the path of the vines move upwards, allowing them to climb higher. Here, the player, once confronted with the end of a certain path or sequence, must reorient in order to expand their capacity for action within a new context. However, these vines reach a dead end, requiring another shift to the right, which leads the player up to a platform. The player must then shift over to the right or left twice to bring a sequence of three platforms embedded in the tower, leading up the wall, into view. On the second platform rests the first cube-bit of the room, a goal directly related to the game's ultimate goal, now revealed through the reorientation of feedback. As the player continues utilizing reorientation in a similar fashion to climb the tower, picking up 8 cube-bits along the way which rewards them with a full cube, they arrive at the top and are able to shift their perspective to open and reveal a door to move forward into the next room.

The manipulation of feedback here notably not only changes the context for action, but, as feedback does, also provides the player the information about their goal structures, such as the position of a cube-bit, which structures the orientation of the action itself. In this one room, the player is provided information about the stative positions of objects such as cubes, climbable objects such as vines or platforms and doors, each situating a different yet structurally similar imperative *reach* goal. To Cardona et al., an imperative goal is a sub-goal in a total hierarchy of

goals that's structured around the final or ultimate goal of a game, such as reconstructing the Hexahedron (3). All of these structures can be considered imperative goals because the player is simply required to utilize their platforming mechanical set to *reach* them, or to "navigate to a particular location," one of the core imperative goals listed in Cardona et al. 's typology (4). Given the fact that the ultimate goal of FEZ is comprised of a complex hierarchy of imperative goals and that this ultimate goal is technically a model-world within Ryan's conception of narrative, each of these imperative goals could also be considered as a kind of sub-model-world, where the player and Gomez are tasked with literally bringing their actual-world closer to alignment with these sub-models. While the total model-world of reconstructing the Hexahedron remains a constant throughout the game, the way in which this model-world, or ultimate goal, is understood on a moment-to-moment basis becomes completely dependent upon the perspective of feedback as provided by the use of reorientation.

This becomes especially important when considering Ryan's conception of intention-worlds, which operate as the intended structure of action dependent on the relation of a character's model-world to their understanding of the actual-world. Intention-worlds are clearly defined as when "a character commits himself, privately or to witnesses, to reaching a certain target by following a certain course of action," (725). These intention-worlds operate as a sort of hinge between the character's knowledge-world, or their understanding of reality as conditioned by their frame of reference, and how their model-world directs that action. Reorientation literalizes this idea; by bringing about a change in feedback, and thus a change in the player's knowledge of current state propositions, it generates a new potential set of sub-model-worlds, and reorganizes the player's ability to reach an actual world closer in line with the ultimate model-world of reconstructing the Hexahedron. The state of the narrative, and the player's

distance from their model-world becomes directly mediated by the intended filtering between signal and noise, and thus perception itself.

Each of these sub-model-worlds or imperative goals established in this introductory area, platforms, cubes/cube-bits and doors, hold their own structural significance as well, while still being necessarily organized around the idea of bringing the player's model-world closer into alignment with the game's actual-world. The cubes and cube-bits operate simply enough: as the player reaches each cube bit, the state proposition of how many more they need to reconstruct the Hexahedron goes down, bringing their model-world into closer proximity. These goals, as being most directly related to the ultimate goal, operate as imperative goals central to the structuring of action as the player traverses the FEZ's world. The goal structure of platforms, in combination with the mechanic of reorientation, however, operate in a slightly more complicated way; for that reason we will return to doors, and room-to-room movement after first outlining how map traversal works in a single room. The nature of platform goals is best highlighted by a later puzzle in the game involving another tower which takes the shape of a donut; on two sides this tower is the shape of a square with a circle cut out of its center, and on the other two, a tall rectangle. In the center of the circle is a cube-bit, clearly establishing an imperative goal to structure action, yet none of the climbable vines afford a clear path to the center of the donut. On the side opposite to where the player enters the room at first, they can find the only immediately reachable vines on the donut, despite them seemingly leading nowhere. However, if the player climbs to the top of these vines and reorients to the right once, the distance between those vines and vines on the other side of the donut that extend further up collapse, allowing the player to continue climbing. Despite at first seeming like a meaningless platform, the top point of these initial vines operates as a specific kind of imperative reach goal, a *position to reorient*, a goal that

only reveals its narrative value, or its shift in proximity between the actual and model worlds, retroactively after a shift in perspective.

This function of reorientation is best understood through Bateson's explication of how shifts in context, in respect to the function of Learning II, are brought about by context markers which operate as a form of punctuation in a sequence of actions. According to Bateson, "the phenomena of Learning II can all be included under the rubric of changes in the manner in which the stream of action and experience is segmented or punctuated into context together with changes in the use of context markers," where context markers and punctuation operate as a means for shifting the mechanical set (310). As previously stated, reorientation, as a literalization of Learning III, operates as a system in which Gomez and the player can manually shift their context for action, punctuating a sequence of action in some capacity whenever their perspective is shifted. In the case of this specific vine puzzle, the player must select and combine the correct *syntagmatic sequence of moves* by climbing the vine to the top, despite its seeming initial irrelevance, and punctuate this syntagmatic string with a correct shift in context. The meaning of this *action-syntagm* is then defined based on how and when the player has punctuated the sequence, as if the player reorients to the left instead of the right after reaching the *position to reorient*, they are not provided with more vines to continue their climb to reach the cube-bit, lessening their shift in proximity and thus narrative significance of this syntagmatic structure.

As the player continues moving along these vines after shifting to the right, turning to the hole-less side of the donut, they must climb the vines on the right hand side of the wall and reorient to the right once again. However, this next reorientation is specifically dependent upon the player's final position as they reorient. If the player fails to move to the highest point of these vines, they simply cannot continue as the continuous ladder of vines will be split apart from this

new perspective. This retroactive definition of the meaning of narrative moves dependent on shifts in context during an action syntagm also finds ground in Jacques Lacan's theories of punctuation. In his essay, *The Subversion of the Subject and the Dialectic of Desire*, wherein Lacan explicates the relationship between desire and language, he describes that meaning is established in a sentence "insofar as a sentence closes its signification only with its last term, each term being anticipated in the construction constituted by the other terms and, inversely, sealing their meaning by its retroactive effects," (682). Each term within a syntagmatic structure is in some capacity anticipated by its preceding terms, yet these terms only gain their "sealed" meaning once the sentence arrives at its final term and punctuation. Before the player shifts to the right again they must move to the top of this vine wall, where after reorienting, it splits these vines up and brings the player directly to the hole housing the cube-bit. In this case of reorientation operating as a form of punctuation, the ultimate narrative meaning of the player's action-syntagm only gains meaning dependent upon the final term selected in that sequence before it is punctuated; the imperative goal of *positions to reorient* reveals the how the meaning of a sequence of action is dependent upon how that sequence is punctuated by shifts in perspective.

This idea of imperative goal driven action articulation confined and defined by the information and mechanical set provided by the context of feedback expands beyond the small scale effects of singular rooms when the imperative reach goal of doors are brought into play. Most rooms in FEZ house some form of an imperative goal, whether a cube or cube-bit that directly relates to the game's stated ultimate goal, or deeper secrets that play a role in the game's second ending. Once the player has found all cubes or cube-bits within a room, as well as uncovered that room's secrets, the room is marked on the player's world map as golden,

providing feedback that the player has nothing imperative left to do there. Doors then are an imperative reach goal that the player must pursue once they have finished all possible progression within a given room, such as reaching all cubes or cube-bits. Entering a door allows the player to move from one room to the next, continuing on their quest to bring their model-world into alignment with the actual. However, given the fractured nature of perspective within FEZ, as produced by the structure of reorientation, the map itself takes on a non-linear and fragmentary form. One room-node may house several doors that branch out into any of the game's four directions; for instance, the player may enter a room from one side and reorient, finding another door and moving into another room that branches out in that new direction. The non-linear nature of this structure, as directed by the manipulation of feedback and context, then forms a similar structure to that of *positions to reorient*, wherein each room gains a kind of retroactive narrative significance as terms in a chain as the player continually reorients themselves to articulate a traversal of the map.

FEZ's map is broken up into four primary sections: the Natural Region, the Industrial District, the Sewers, and the Cemetery. Each of these environments are linked together through the game's mode of fast travel, a Warp Gate, which depending on the player's current orientation and view of, opens up a portal to one of these environments. Given their general distance and discrete nature, as structured by the Warp Gate, each of these environments could be considered as a kind of singular entity, a sub-world for exploration housing a number of cubes and cube-bits to be found by the player. Naturally, the non-linear structure of the map requires the player to explore these environments in a fragmentary manner and temporarily leave certain doors and paths as noise during their progression through the world. However, the game itself accounts for this; as the player explores the map, achieving imperative goals and attempting to exhaust each

room of its narrative significance, they eventually reach end-points in the map structure. These end points are distinct given they house Minor Warp Gates, which send the player back to the center and beginning of the environment and cannot be teleported back to.

When considering the interaction between the mechanic reorientation and the environment itself, the player's relationship to space could be directly defined as *anamorphic*, in the sense that the perspective in which the player views the space of any given core environment changes the structure of how it may be traversed. This conception of these environment falls neatly in-line with how reorientation already functions in Moles's conception of noise and signal, where the player ignores certain aspects of information in order to bring others into the foreground; in this case, as the player completes a room, the orientation of their feedback, if it portrays a door within it and establishes it as an imperative reach goal, will likely direct the player onwards in that direction. If other doors exist in the environment, they won't be established as imperative goals by the feedback unless the player reorients to transform them from noise into signal. Here, through the limitation of perception established by reorientation, each room-node in the map's total network gains a certain significance not just as its own individual entity with cubes and cube-bits, but as a moment for *selection* as the player traverses the larger map.

This necessary limitation that derives from the anchoring of a given anamorphic perspective, falls directly in line with the principle of *exclusion* that Lacan finds so essential to syntagmatic sequences. In an analysis of Lacan's own discourse, specifically in reference to his work on the gaze and the way in which a particular view of an object brings about a particular kind of desire, Maria Scott makes an important point about how Lacan viewed the relation of the

gaze to the symbolic, and subjectivity in general. In reference to Lacan's discussion on Holbein's anamorphic painting *The Ambassadors*, Scott notes that:

For Lacan, this anamorphic painting dramatizes the workings of human vision and, analogically, the constitution of subjectivity: elements within the optical field must be repressed if clear vision is to be enabled, just as repression is foundational to the subject's entry into the Lacanian Symbolic Order, the order of language. (328).

In the case of FEZ's core environments, akin to Lacan's understanding of Holbein's paintings, potential spaces of possibility for moving through the map are repressed by the structuring of certain goals. As the player reads the feedback provided to them of their environment, an encounter between the player's gaze and an object, specific goals or desires are brought about, such as the imperative reach goals of a door, which drives the player forward, syntagmatically into a specific articulation of the environment in action. Yet, as these goals and paths for traversal are established, others are excluded, left to the background of information perception, leaving each perspective of the map anamorphically incomplete.

This incompleteness, as each room-node plays a specific role in the player's movement through the map structure as determined by anamorphic feedback, is what drives the player to move through the same nodes over and over again, investing them with new meaning within the syntagmatic structure of room progression. As the player reaches a dead end in the map, a room housing no new doors except for the one the player came from, they are typically provided with a Minor Warp Gate that punctuates their movement through the map and sends them back to their current Major Warp Gate. This punctuation is what finalizes a *map-articulation* that invests each node traversed in this player's path with its contextualized meaning as a step in this larger

action-syntagma. This punctuation notably also sends the player back to the beginning of the environment, at once motivating them to re-traverse or re-articulate their current environment in some way. The linear progression of movement through the environment, as articulated as a larger action-syntagma, thus drives the player to attempt to exhaust their previously excluded terms.

This movement through FEZ's map also reflects what Lacan considers one of the core effects of the necessitated exclusion that occurs on the part of a subject's entrance into a symbolic order: *repetition automatism*. Upon entrance into the symbolic, certain aspects of reality are lost to the form of language, whilst simultaneously, the progression of a syntagmatic structure necessitates the exclusion of potential terms from its articulation. Due to this, Lacan finds that a subject is necessarily compelled to re-articulate events over and over again, in an attempt to try and exhaust their *real* meaning, an inaccessible object. In his explication of the structure of the L-Chain in his *Seminar on the Purloined Letter*, after showing the way in which a syntagmatic structure necessitates a retrospective exclusion of terms, Lacan describes how this exclusion directly relates to the structure of *repetition automatism*:

This could illustrate a rudimentary subjective trajectory, by showing that it is grounded in the actuality which has the future anterior in its present. The fact that, in the interval of this past that it is already insofar as it projects, a hole opens up that is constituted by a certain *caput mortuum* of the signifier (which is set here at three-quarters of the possible combinations in which it must situate itself), suffices to make it depend on absence, obliging it to repeat its contour. (37-8).

In this analysis of a syntagmatic sequence he constructs for the purposes of explicating the laws of symbolic structures, this quote highlights that through the limits of terms from the chain's

possibility space, impossibilities of expression, symbolic sequences are compelled to circumlocute in a futile attempt to circle their limitations. In the case of FEZ, while the player moves through the map, articulating the environment in specific ways dependent upon the anamorphic gaze of their feedback which limits and defines the meaning of each room, other rooms are excluded from the syntagmatic expression. This exclusion of a linear traversal of a non-linear space defines certain potentialities of the map's rooms as mutually exclusive expressions, forcing the player to rearticulate the map again from the beginning. Through the fracturing of Gomez's perception, the environment itself reveals the always present limitations of any given perspective; Lacan shortly after states that "subjectivity has no relation to the real, but rather to a syntax which is engendered by the signifying mark there," and the virtual reality of these maps face the same limitations thrust upon them by the context of the mechanical structures by which players traverse them with (38). As the player attempts to exhaust the possibilities for meaning within the game of FEZ, they're necessarily forced to repeat that which was excluded in the non-linear possibility space of each room's meaning, while each room only gains a meaning contingent upon the given map-articulation, eliding its virtual reality through symbolic engagement.

With this larger scale of the syntagmatic structure of action defined by reorientation, it's worth reviewing the way in which each of these parts connect to one another as a part of the mechanic. Reorientation operates as a direct manipulation of feedback, which establishes both the context for action through changing the player's possibility space as well as the goals that condition player action. The player's proximity to achieving these goals plays a direct role in the narrative significance of their action, as these goals operate as moves made to bring the player and Gomez's model world closer into alignment with the actual world of the game. The

proximity to these goals, and the way in which each action, and each room relates to them, is determined retroactively by moments of punctuation, often marked by the player's choice of orientation and thus changes in context. As the player progresses through certain chains of action on the micro and macro, other possibilities for action fall to the background of their sensory perception, necessitating a return to environments and obstacles previously encountered in order to attempt to exhaust them of their narrative significance by encountering them from a different perspective. Though, due to the fact that each environment only gains its narrative significance in the context of a specific punctuated sequence, its multifarious virtual reality seems to escape any single articulation of the game's mechanics. Through the way in which any given perspective or context includes certain terms while excluding others, reorientation reveals the reality of how the meaning of any given object, as well as possible action towards one, is dependent upon how one is capable of parsing signals from said object, thus, and on perception; the possibility space for action and the potential meaning of an object might then be considered to be inexhaustible if one continually shifts their context of perception.

However, due to the limitations of the game's own mechanics, FEZ's possibility space becomes seemingly exhaustible as the player reaches closer and closer to their ultimate goal of putting the Hexahedron, and thus Gomez's reality back together. Each room becomes exhausted of its own imperative goals as well as its meaning in relation to imperative goals nodally linked to its possibility space as the player collects each cube scattered throughout the map. The potentialities for action begin to narrow as the player brings the actual world closer into alignment with their ultimate goal through the exploration of this non-linear space. This natural conclusion and return to a clean and simple equilibrium, however, is in fact subverted by the game's own progression system and the many secrets scattered throughout its world. Once the

player gathers all 32 cubes, allowing them to reassemble the Hexahedron, the game technically ends, only to prompt the player to start again with New Game +. While this trope is fairly common in video game form, FEZ's variation affords the player with new ways of seeing that once again expand the possibility space for action within the world, challenging a straightforward conclusion.

When the player opens up NG+ and reenounters the Hexahedron, instead of the titular fez that Gomez is already wearing, the player is given the First Person Glasses, which allow them to view the world directly from Gomez's eyes. This mechanic, while not as reality transfiguring as the core mechanic of reorientation, becomes an essential tool for the player navigating and reaching the game's second, secret ending. In order to achieve this ending, the player must not only collect all 32 cubes, but also 32 anti-cubes, 4 heart cubes, and to find and solve every possible secret puzzle embedded within the game world. While the completion of the first ending brings the player's progression directly to 100% completion, this second ending concludes with the player's progress arriving at 209%. The First Person Glasses become essential for this ending since the view provided by the orientation of the camera within this person often still excludes, or literally occludes, information from the environment. In order to parse certain signals and to solve more deeply embedded puzzles this second time through, the player must quite literally change their perspective once again. Thus, the game's world as explored purely through the context of reorientation, seemingly exhausted of possibility for action, is opened up once more in NG+.

One of the most relevant forms of secrets that are opened up within NG+ are the hidden Tetromino codes. Throughout the world, the player may find lines or sequences, syntagma, composed of tetris-like blocks that at first glance only operate as a signal that the player is

currently unable to parse some element of the game's information. As the player progresses further through the game they will eventually come across a mechanical device that lights up different tetris-like patterns depending upon which button the player is pressing at any given moment. Each of these patterns corresponds directly to the game's core action inputs: movement, jumping and reorientation. By decoding this language constructed from the player's mechanical set, the previous noise of these markings found throughout the world into a readable signal. However, in order to properly parse these signals, the player must not only learn the structure of their language, entering them into a new symbolic order, but must also turn their head sideways to read the sequence in its proper order, expanding the structure of reorientation and anamorphism outside of the interiority of the game's system.

Once these modes of reading the Tetromino codes are discovered, the player is provided direct access to an action-syntagma through expanding their ways of seeing; new possibility spaces of action are once again made real through a shift in symbolic as well as literal perspective. When the player correctly inputs these sequences, secrets such as hidden doors will open up, providing the player with punctuation to the sequence, and once again, retroactively determining the meaning of the preceding action-syntagm. Given the fact that these action-inputs are quite literally deciphered as a symbolic relation to the perception and reception of feedback, these puzzles seem to solidify the linguistically structured nature of sequences of action, and the way in which goal structures contextualize the meaning of the mechanical sets that provide the player the terms for action articulation. In line with Lacan's understanding of repetition automatism, that which a single symbolic order, or anamorphic perspective, excludes from its linguistic possibility, necessitates new ways of seeing in order to attempt to exhaust the possibility of the object. The Tetronominos reveal the fundamental relationship of the human

receptor's ability to extract signal from noise to construct a possibility space for action, where action becomes dependent upon what is directly perceived as a possible goal.

However, even with this 209% completion of the game having been solved, one specific Tetromino puzzle, the Black Monolith, has yet to be solved organically by the game's community. This puzzle was solved fairly shortly after the released date through a brute force attempt, wherein the online community put together a giant list of possible Tetromino sequences and tried them at random until arriving at the solution. The solution was found, but the developers stated that this brute force attempt was *not* the way in which they had intended for the puzzle to be completed; there is still, fourteen years after the game's release, no confirmation of how the game would lead the player to the conclusion of this sequence. With the solution of the puzzle in mind, players have retroactively extracted many different theories about how they might go about finding this sequence both in and outside of the game, with one debunked theory even utilizing the game's release date to derive the sequence. However, many of these theories struggle with utilizing an arbitrary arrangement of information within the world, arrangements that are found by using the Tetromino code itself to read signal from noise in the environment. These arbitrarily parsed signals fail to encapsulate any seemingly *natural* way in which the player might read the environment and arrive at the conclusion without previous knowledge of the code.

To consider this puzzle within the context of fragmentation and an intention based perspective of reality, the seeming impossibility of organically finding the puzzle's solution, and thus organically using one's perception to put the game's reality back together, points towards an impossibility of truly reconstructing a reality that's been fragmented by Learning III; a reality that's been proven to be totally dependent upon a manipulateable perception of contexts and

ways of seeing cannot simply return to a stable frame of reference. In regards to the the 209% ending's relation to the distance between model and actual worlds established in the beginning of the game, while the gap may have been closed arbitrarily through a brute force mechanism, the ability for the player to truly close that gap with their own perception reaches a sort of asymptotic point. After the fragmentation of reality, Gomez and the community of FEZ itself are left stranded, scanning the environment for clues to a puzzle now determined only retroactively by their desired point of arrival. The ways of seeing the world through the lens of the Black Monolith's Tetromino sequence border on a kind of paranoid attention to noise, where anything can become the desired signal if parsed in such a way to arrive at the conclusion. None of them, however, actually align with reality, and the players are driven to break apart the game's virtual reality, piece by piece in order to attempt to fully exhaust its meaning. Rather than simply ending in a clean narrative equilibrium, the model world seems to remain in orbit around reality, where the solution to bringing them together drives a continual search for new ways of seeing. FEZ then, through ending with an equilibrium of disequilibrium where there still is no confirmation of a correct way of seeing, points towards the inexhaustibility of reality as directly mediated by perception; the real world, which has nothing to do with the perceptual apparatus structured by symbolic law, holds its subjects in an elliptical orbit where they are left circling the world in search of a seemingly futile, totalizing conclusion.

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